No Path-breaking Agriculture Development Strategy after the Green Revolution

No new agriculture development strategy has been deployed in the country in the past three decades. Today's agriculture development programmes are mostly repackaged versions of the programmes initiated during the green revolution phase (1965–1990). The HYV programme of the 1960s–1970s was reorganized as the Mini-kit Programme for Rice, Wheat and Coarse Grains and Integrated Cereals Development Programme—Rice/Coarse Cereals/Wheat-Based Cropping System and Development of Pulses. These programmes became part of the Rashtriya Krishi Vikas Yojana (RKVY) and the National Food Security Mission (NFSM) in 2007–08. Horticulture programmes were converted into the National Horticulture Mission in 2003. In 2015, the agriculture and allied sector production and productivity programmes were reorganized under the three umbrellas of green revolution, white revolution and blue revolution programmes, without really changing anything. In effect, production and productivity enhancement programmes in the past three decades have been nothing but old wine in new bottles.

That said, agriculture development programmes did witness a differentiated approach to achieve productivity gains during this period. Eastern India had a much better water regime but relatively poor productivity of foodgrain crops. Agriculture development programmes were focused on this region in this phase. Agriculture in Bihar turned around. There have also been notable gains in other eastern and northeastern states. More attention was paid on pulse cultivation, horticulture and proteins (milk, meat) as the food crisis receded. India achieved 90 per cent self-sufficiency in pulses and became the largest milk producer. The production of fruits and vegetables also went up considerably.

Well irrigation expanded to about 60 million hectares (almost thrice that of canal irrigation). Programmatic interventions to popularize the use of